Chapter 10 — Object-Oriented Programming in Python

What you will learn. Classes and instances, `__init__` and `self`, class vs instance attributes, the three kinds of method, properties. The *data model* — "dunder" methods (`__repr__`, `__eq__`, `__hash__`, `__lt__`, `__len__`, `__iter__`, `__getitem__`, `__call__`, `__enter__` …) that make your classes work with `len()`, `for`, `==`, `+`, `with`, `sorted()`. Reuse: inheritance (a class reusing and extending another) and `super()`, the method resolution order (MRO), multiple inheritance, mixins, abstract base classes, duck typing and `Protocol`, composition vs inheritance. The modern toolbox — `dataclasses`, `enum`, `__slots__` — encapsulation (keeping internals behind methods) conventions, and Pythonic design patterns (named, reusable solutions to common design problems).

Prerequisites. Functions, basic types, exceptions. SOLID (five classic OO design principles) and the Gang-of-Four patterns (23 patterns from the 1994 book *Design Patterns*) are covered language-neutrally in the LLD Handbook (LLD = low-level design); this chapter is about *how Python does OOP*.

Code. Scripts are in `chapters/10-oop-in-python/code/` and run on Python 3.12+ with no dependencies:

```
python chapters/10-oop-in-python/code/data_model.py
```



10.1 Classes and instances, `__init__` and `self`

What it is

A **class** is a blueprint bundling data (**attributes**) and behaviour (**methods**). An **instance** (*object*) is one concrete thing built from it — cookie cutter vs cookies. In Python *everything* is an object — ints, functions, modules, and classes themselves (a class is an instance of `type`).

Why it matters

State and the code that changes it live together, so invariants (rules that must always hold: "balance never negative") are enforced in one place.

How it works

1. `class BankAccount: ...` runs the body once and creates a class object.
2. Calling it, `BankAccount("Asha", 100)`: `__new__` allocates an empty instance, then `__init__` initialises it. You rarely write `__new__` (immutable types, instance caching, metaclass tricks — a *metaclass* is the class of a class).
3. `__init__(self, ...)` receives the new instance first; `self` is a convention, not a keyword.
4. `self.owner = owner` stores an **instance attribute** in the instance's namespace dict, `obj.__dict__`.
5. `__init__` returns `None`; it *initialises*, not *constructs*.

Class attributes vs instance attributes

A **class attribute** is defined in the class body and shared; an **instance attribute** is set on `self`, one per object.

Attribute lookup for `obj.name` (simplified): `obj.__dict__`, then the class, then parents along the MRO (§10.5). Assigning `obj.name = ...` always writes to the *instance*, *shadowing* (hiding) any class attribute.

The three kinds of method

Kind	Decorator	First parameter	Typical use
Instance method	none	`self` (the instance)	Read/modify one object's state
Class method	`@classmethod`	`cls` (the class)	Alternative constructors (`from_csv`, `dict.fromkeys`, `datetime.fromtimestamp`); subclass-friendly because `cls` is the subclass
Static method	`@staticmethod`	none	Helper belonging to the class, needing neither instance nor class

`a.deposit` is a **bound method** — the function with `self` pre-filled — so `a.deposit(5)` ≡ `BankAccount.deposit(a, 5)`. (Mechanism: functions are *descriptors*, objects customising attribute lookup — Chapter 12.)

Properties

A **property** makes a method look like an attribute. Start with a plain public attribute; when you later need validation or computation, turn it into a property and **no caller changes** — so Python needs no Java-style getters/setters (`get_x()` / `set_x()`).

```python
class BankAccount:
    bank_name = "PyBank"          # class attribute: shared by every instance
    _next_id = 1                  # class attribute used as a counter

    def __init__(self, owner: str, balance: float = 0.0) -> None:
        self.owner = owner        # instance attributes: one copy per object
        self._balance = balance   # leading underscore = "internal, please don't touch"
        self.id = BankAccount._next_id
        BankAccount._next_id += 1

    def deposit(self, amount: float) -> None:          # instance method
        if amount <= 0:
            raise ValueError("amount must be positive")
        self._balance += amount

    @property
    def balance(self) -> float:                        # read like an attribute
        return self._balance

    @balance.setter
    def balance(self, value: float) -> None:           # validated assignment
        if value < 0:
            raise ValueError("balance cannot be negative")
        self._balance = value

    @classmethod
    def from_csv(cls, line: str) -> "BankAccount":     # alternative constructor
        owner, balance = line.split(",")
        return cls(owner, float(balance))

    @staticmethod
    def is_valid_amount(amount: float) -> bool:        # plain helper
        return amount > 0


class Buggy:
    items = []                    # MISTAKE: one list shared by all instances
    def add(self, x):
        self.items.append(x)
```

The demo builds two accounts (one via the class method), shadows `bank_name` on `a`, has the setter reject a negative value, proves `a.deposit` is bound, and shows the shared-mutable-class-attribute bug (`self.items.append` mutates the one class list — no assignment, so no shadowing).

Output (`classes_basics.py`):

```
a: Asha 125 id 1
b: Ben 50.0 id 2
static check: False
a.bank_name: PyBank
after assignment -> a: Shadow | b: PyBank | class: PyBank
a.__dict__: {'owner': 'Asha', '_balance': 125, 'id': 1, 'bank_name': 'Shadow'}
setter refused: balance cannot be negative
a.deposit is bound: True
after unbound call: 130
Buggy y.items: [1]
Fixed q.items: []
```

Trade-offs

Choice	Good for	Watch out
Plain public attribute	Simple data, zero overhead	Can't validate — but can become a property later without breaking callers
Property	Validation, computed values, read-only views	Hides work behind attribute syntax; keep it cheap
Class attribute	Constants, defaults, shared counters	Mutable class attributes are shared — a classic bug
`@classmethod` vs `@staticmethod`	`cls` makes alternative constructors subclass-friendly	A static method naming the class directly breaks for subclasses

When not to use a class

One function, no state → a function. Data, no behaviour → `dataclass`, `NamedTuple` or `dict`. A class with only `__init__` and one method is often a function in disguise (Jack Diederich, "Stop Writing Classes", PyCon).

Common mistakes

- Missing `self` → `TypeError: takes 0 positional arguments but 1 was given`.
- Mutable class attributes (`items = []`) — initialise in `__init__`.
- Mutable default arguments (`def __init__(self, items=[])`) — use `None` (§7.2).
- `self._next_id += 1` creates an instance attribute; update the class: `type(self)._next_id += 1`.
- Property and attribute with the same name (`self.balance = x` inside the `balance` setter) → infinite recursion; store in `_balance`.

Real-world examples

- Class-method constructors: `datetime.datetime.fromtimestamp`, `dict.fromkeys`, `int.from_bytes`.
- Properties: `pathlib.Path.name`, `.suffix`, `.parent`.
- Django model fields are class attributes; instances hold their own values.

In the interview

30-second answer: "A class is a blueprint; instances are built by `__new__` then initialised by `__init__`, which gets the instance as `self`. Class attributes live on the class and are shared; instance attributes live in each object's `__dict__`, and lookup checks the instance first, then the class and its parents. Instance methods take `self`, class methods take `cls` and are used for alternative constructors, static methods take neither. Properties let me add validation later without changing the public API."

- *Why is `self` explicit?* — "Explicit is better than implicit": a method is a function on the class; `obj.m()` passes `obj` first. It also makes instance vs local variables obvious.

- *Factory (object-creating function) as class or static method?* — Class method, so `SubClass.from_csv(...)` returns a `SubClass`.
- `__new__` *for?* — Controlling creation: subclassing immutables (`int`, `str`, `tuple`), caching instances, metaclasses.

TL;DR

Classes bundle state and behaviour; `__init__` initialises `self`. Instance attributes per object, class attributes shared (beware mutable ones). Instance/class/static methods take `self`/`cls`/nothing. Public attributes first; properties when needed.

10.2 The data model: dunder methods

What it is

The **Python data model** is the set of special methods — **double underscore** names like `__len__` — that the interpreter calls behind syntax and built-ins: `len(x)` → `x.__len__()`, `a + b` → `a.__add__(b)`, `for` → `__iter__`, `with` → `__enter__/__exit__`. *Fluent Python* calls it Python's "metaobject protocol" (the rules by which objects plug into the language).

Why it matters

Your classes get the familiar interface — `len(playlist)`, `playlist[0]`, `sorted(vectors)`, `v1 + v2`, `print(v)` — and plug into the standard library (`sorted`, `max`, `set`, `dict`, `random.choice`, `in`) for free.

How it works — the most important dunders

You write	Python calls	Notes
`repr(x)`, REPL echo, inside containers	`__repr__`	Unambiguous, for developers; ideally like the constructor call
`str(x)`, `print(x)`, `f"{x}"`	`__str__`	Readable, for users; **falls back to** `__repr__`
`x == y`, `x != y`	`__eq__`, `__ne__`	Default is identity; `__ne__` inverts `__eq__` automatically
`hash(x)`, dict key, set member	`__hash__`	Must agree with `__eq__`
`x < y` etc.	`__lt__`, `__le__`, `__gt__`, `__ge__`	`@functools.total_ordering` derives the rest from `__eq__` + one of them
`len(x)`	`__len__`	Must return an int ≥ 0
`bool(x)`, `if x:`	`__bool__`	Falls back to `__len__() != 0`, else `True`
`for i in x`, `iter(x)`	`__iter__`	Falls back to `__getitem__(0), (1), …` until `IndexError`
`x[k]`, `x[a:b]`	`__getitem__`	Receives an int, key, or `slice` object
`x[k] = v`, `del x[k]`	`__setitem__`, `__delitem__`	
`v in x`	`__contains__`	Falls back to iterating
`x(args)`	`__call__`	Makes instances callable
`with x as y:`	`__enter__`, `__exit__`	Chapter 12
`a + b`, `a * b`, `abs(a)`, `-a`	`__add__`, `__mul__`, `__abs__`, `__neg__`	Operator overloading (§10.3)

`__eq__` and `__hash__` — the contract

A **hash** is the integer dicts and sets use to pick a slot (§6.2). Rule: **if** `a == b` **then** `hash(a) == hash(b)` (collisions — different values sharing a hash — are allowed).

1. By default objects compare and hash by identity — consistent.
2. Defining `__eq__` without `__hash__` makes Python set `__hash__ = None` — instances become **unhashable**, protecting the rule.
3. To restore hashing, hash the *same* fields `__eq__` uses: `hash((self.x, self.y))`.
4. Hash only **immutable** state — a key mutated inside a dict sits in the wrong slot and is "lost". `frozen=True` dataclasses (§10.10) are the easy route.

`NotImplemented`

When a comparison or arithmetic method can't handle the other operand, **return** (don't raise) the singleton `NotImplemented`. Python then tries the reflected method on the other operand (`b.__radd__(a)`, or `b.__eq__(a)`) and raises `TypeError` only if both give up.

```python
@total_ordering
class Vector:
    __match_args__ = ("x", "y")

    def __init__(self, x: float, y: float) -> None:
        self.x, self.y = x, y

    def __repr__(self) -> str:
        return f"Vector({self.x!r}, {self.y!r})"

    def __str__(self) -> str:
        return f"({self.x}, {self.y})"

    def __eq__(self, other: object) -> bool:
        if not isinstance(other, Vector):
            return NotImplemented
        return (self.x, self.y) == (other.x, other.y)

    def __hash__(self) -> int:
        return hash((self.x, self.y))

    def __lt__(self, other: "Vector") -> bool:     # total_ordering adds <=, >, >=
        if not isinstance(other, Vector):
            return NotImplemented
        return abs(self) < abs(other)

    def __add__(self, other): ...                   # see §10.3
    def __abs__(self) -> float:
        return math.hypot(self.x, self.y)
    def __bool__(self) -> bool:
        return bool(self.x or self.y)
    def __iter__(self):                             # enables x, y = v
        yield self.x
        yield self.y


class Playlist:
    def __init__(self, *songs: str) -> None:
        self._songs = list(songs)
    def __len__(self) -> int:
        return len(self._songs)
    def __getitem__(self, index):                   # ints AND slices
        result = self._songs[index]
        return Playlist(*result) if isinstance(index, slice) else result
    def __contains__(self, song: str) -> bool:
        return song in self._songs


class Multiplier:
    def __init__(self, factor: int) -> None:
        self.factor, self.calls = factor, 0
    def __call__(self, x: int) -> int:              # instance used like a function
        self.calls += 1
        return x * self.factor


class Timer:
    def __enter__(self):
        print("  enter: start timer")
        return self                                  # bound to the `as` name
    def __exit__(self, exc_type, exc, tb) -> bool:
        print(f"  exit: stop timer (exception={exc_type.__name__ if exc_type else None})")
        return False                                 # don't swallow exceptions
```

Output (`data_model.py`):

```
repr: Vector(3, 4) | str: (3, 4) | f-string: (3, 4)
v + w = (4, 5) | v * 2 = (6, 8) | 2 * v = (6, 8)
abs(v) = 5.0 | bool(Vector(0,0)) = False
v == Vector(3,4): True | v is Vector(3,4): False
w < v: True | v >= w: True (>= from total_ordering)
set dedups equal vectors: {Vector(1, 2)}
sorted: [Vector(1, 1), Vector(0, 2), Vector(3, 4)]
unpacked: 3 4
pattern matched, y = 4
TypeError: unsupported operand type(s) for +: 'Vector' and 'int'
len: 4 | p[0]: intro | p[-1]: outro | p[1:3]: Playlist('verse', 'chorus')
'chorus' in p: True | iterate via __getitem__: ['INTRO', 'VERSE', 'CHORUS', 'OUTRO']
callable: 15 21 calls = 2 | callable(): True
  enter: start timer
  inside block, t is a Timer: True
  exit: stop timer (exception=None)
  enter: start timer
  exit: stop timer (exception=KeyError)
  KeyError still propagated
__hash__ of class defining only __eq__: None
```

`Playlist` has no `__iter__`, yet `for` works via the legacy `__getitem__` fallback; negative indexes and slices work by delegating to the list. `__match_args__` lets `match v: case Vector(3, y)` destructure positionally. The last line proves the `__eq__`-without-`__hash__` rule. `print([v])` uses `__repr__` (containers show item reprs).

This teaching `Vector` is mutable *and* hashable — fine only if never mutated while used as a key; in production make it immutable (frozen dataclass or read-only properties).

Trade-offs

Approach	Pros	Cons
Dunders by hand	Full control, any semantics	Boilerplate; easy to make `__eq__`/`__hash__` inconsistent
`@dataclass`	Generates `__init__`, `__repr__`, `__eq__` (optionally ordering/hash)	Field-by-field semantics only
Inherit `collections.abc.Sequence`/`Mapping`	Implement 2–3 abstract methods, get `index`, `count`, `__contains__`, `__iter__`, `__reversed__` as mixin methods	Ties you to that ABC
Subclass `list`/`dict` directly	Quick	C methods often bypass your overrides (`dict.update` ignores your `__setitem__`); prefer `collections.UserDict`/`UserList`

When not to use it

No surprising operator meanings (`+` that deletes a file). No `__call__` for cleverness — only when the object genuinely *is* function-like (a model, strategy, validator).

Common mistakes

- Calling `x.__len__()` instead of `len(x)` (the built-in is faster for built-ins and adds checks).
- `raise NotImplementedError` in `__eq__`/`__add__` instead of `return NotImplemented`.
- Surprise at unhashability after defining `__eq__`.
- Useless `__repr__` like `<object>` — include key fields.
- Non-int/non-bool from `__len__`/`__bool__` → `TypeError`.

Real-world examples

- `pathlib.Path` overloads `/` (`__truediv__`): `Path("a") / "b"`.

- NumPy/pandas overload arithmetic, comparison and `__getitem__` (boolean masks — True/False arrays selecting elements — and slicing).
- `requests.Session`, files, `threading.Lock`, `sqlite3.Connection` implement `__enter__/__exit__`.
- PyTorch `nn.Module.__call__` runs hooks (user-registered callbacks) then `forward()` — hence `model(x)`.
- SQLAlchemy (maps classes to database tables) overloads `==`, `<` on columns to build SQL (`User.age > 18`).

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "The data model is Python's protocol of special methods: built-ins and syntax call dunders — `len` calls `__len__`, `+` calls `__add__`, `for` calls `__iter__`. Implementing them makes custom classes behave like built-ins and work with the standard library. Key rules: `__repr__` for developers, `__str__` falls back to it; `__eq__` and `__hash__` must agree and defining `__eq__` alone makes the class unhashable; return `NotImplemented` for unsupported operands."

- *Why equal objects need equal hashes?* — The hash picks a bucket (hash-table slot), then `==` confirms; different hashes → different buckets → duplicates.
- *Minimum to be iterable?* — `__iter__` returning an iterator, or `__getitem__` for 0, 1, 2… raising `IndexError` at the end.
- *`__str__` vs `__repr__`?* — `str` falls back to `repr`, not vice versa — write `__repr__` first.

TL;DR

Dunders are hooks for syntax and built-ins. Always `__repr__`. Keep `__eq__`/`__hash__` consistent on immutable fields. Return `NotImplemented`. `__len__`/`__getitem__`/`__iter__`/`__contains__` for containers, `__call__` for callables, `__enter__/__exit__` for `with`.

10.3 Operator overloading

What it is

Operator overloading gives `+`, `-`, `*`, `@`, `==`, `<`, `[]` etc. meaning for your types via the matching dunder.

How it works

For `a + b`:

1. `a.__add__(b)`; a non-`NotImplemented` result wins.
2. Else the **reflected** `b.__radd__(a)`. (If `type(b)` is a *subclass* of `type(a)` that overrides `__radd__`, it's tried first.)
3. Both `NotImplemented` → `TypeError: unsupported operand type(s)`.

For `a += b`, the **in-place** `a.__iadd__(b)` is tried first (may mutate and `return self`); if missing, `a = a + b`. Hence `list += ...` mutates while `tuple += ...` builds a new tuple, and `lst += (1,)` works (`__iadd__` accepts any iterable, like `extend`) while `lst = lst + (1,)` fails (`__add__` wants a list).

Operator	Method	Reflected	In-place
`+`	`__add__`	`__radd__`	`__iadd__`
`-`	`__sub__`	`__rsub__`	`__isub__`
`*`	`__mul__`	`__rmul__`	`__imul__`
`@` (matrix mult)	`__matmul__`	`__rmatmul__`	`__imatmul__`
`/`, `//`, `%`, `**`	`__truediv__`, `__floordiv__`, `__mod__`, `__pow__`	`__r…__`	`__i…__`
`&`, `|`, `^`	`__and__`, `__or__`, `__xor__`	`__r…__`	`__i…__`
unary `-`, `+`, `~`, `abs()`	`__neg__`, `__pos__`, `__invert__`, `__abs__`	—	—

Comparisons have no `__r…__` versions; they reflect each other: if `a < b` is `NotImplemented`, Python tries `b > a`.

```
    def __add__(self, other: "Vector") -> "Vector":
        if not isinstance(other, Vector):
            return NotImplemented
        return Vector(self.x + other.x, self.y + other.y)

    def __mul__(self, k: float) -> "Vector":      # v * 3
        if not isinstance(k, (int, float)):
            return NotImplemented
        return Vector(self.x * k, self.y * k)

    __rmul__ = __mul__                            # 3 * v  (int.__mul__ returns NotImplemented)
```

`2 * v` works only via `__rmul__`: `int.__mul__(2, v)` returns `NotImplemented`, so Python calls `v.__rmul__(2)`.

Common mistakes

- No `__rmul__` → `v * 2` works, `2 * v` fails.
- `__iadd__` forgetting `return self` → the variable becomes `None`.
- Mutating operands inside `__add__` — return a *new* object.

Real-world examples

`Decimal`, `Fraction`, `datetime - timedelta`, `set | set`, `dict | dict` (3.9+), NumPy `@` (PEP 465), `pathlib` `/`.

In the interview

30-second answer: "Each operator maps to a dunder. For `a + b` Python calls `a.__add__(b)`; if that returns `NotImplemented` it tries `b.__radd__(a)`, then raises `TypeError`. `+=` tries `__iadd__` for in-place update and falls back to `+`. Return `NotImplemented` for unsupported types so the other operand gets a chance."

TL;DR

Operators are dunders. Return `NotImplemented` for unknown types; `__r…__` for "other type on the left", `__i…__` for in-place updates.

10.4 Inheritance and `super()`

What it is

Inheritance lets a **subclass** (child) reuse and specialise a **base class** (parent): `class Manager(Employee)` gets all parent attributes and methods and can **override** them. It models **is-a**.

How it works

1. Lookup on a `Manager` searches `Manager`, `Employee`, then `object` (every class's ultimate base).
2. To extend a parent method, call **`super()`** — a proxy forwarding lookups to the *next* class in the MRO.
3. A child `__init__` does **not** auto-call the parent's; call `super().__init__(...)`.
4. `isinstance(obj, Cls)` checks the class and ancestors; `issubclass(A, B)` checks classes. Prefer `isinstance` over `type(x) == Cls`, which ignores subclasses.

```
class Employee:
    def __init__(self, name: str, salary: int) -> None:
        self.name, self.salary = name, salary
    def pay(self) -> int:
        return self.salary
    def __repr__(self) -> str:
        return f"{type(self).__name__}({self.name!r})"   # type(self) -> works for subclasses


class Manager(Employee):
    def __init__(self, name: str, salary: int, bonus: int) -> None:
        super().__init__(name, salary)      # reuse the parent's initialiser
        self.bonus = bonus
    def pay(self) -> int:                    # override, then extend
        return super().pay() + self.bonus
```

Output: `Manager('Mia') pays 120 | isinstance Employee: True | issubclass: True`

Common mistakes

- Forgetting `super().__init__()` → missing parent attributes → `AttributeError` later.
- Hard-coding `Employee.__init__(self, ...)` — breaks cooperative multiple inheritance (§10.5).
- Deep hierarchies (5+ levels) — prefer composition (§10.8).
- Overriding with an incompatible signature — violates the Liskov Substitution Principle (a subclass must work wherever its parent does; LLD Handbook ch. 4).

TL;DR

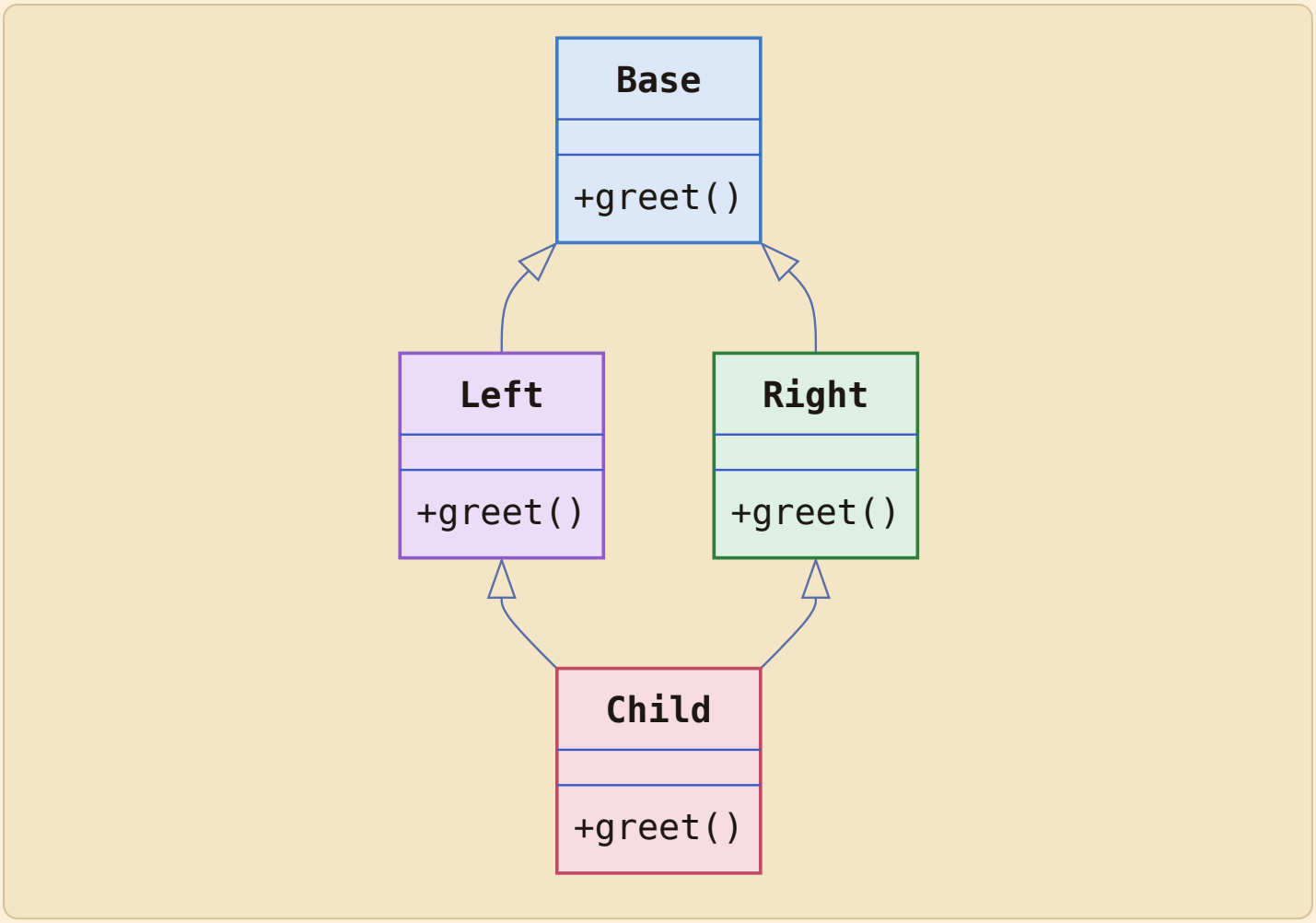
Subclass for true is-a; override to specialise; `super()` to extend; always call `super().__init__`.

10.5 Multiple inheritance and the MRO (C3 linearization)

What it is

`class Child(Left, Right)` has several bases. The **method resolution order (MRO)** is the single ordered list of classes searched for attributes (`Child.__mro__` / `Child.mro()`), computed by **C3 linearization** (since Python 2.3).

The problem it solves — the diamond



Which `greet` runs, and does `Base.greet` run once or twice? C3 gives one consistent answer with `Base` exactly once.

How it works — C3 in plain words

MRO(class) = the class + a **merge** of its parents' MROs and the parent list, obeying:

1. **Children before parents.**
2. **Local order kept** — bases in written order (`Left` before `Right`).
3. **Monotonic** — each parent's MRO order is preserved.

Worked example, `Child(Left, Right)`: lists [Left, Base, object], [Right, Base, object], [Left, Right]. Merge = repeatedly take the first head (first element) not in any other list's *tail* (everything after the head):

- `Left` — in no tail → take.
- `Base` — in the tail of [Right, Base, object] → skip; `Right` → take.
- `Base` now free → take; then `object`.
- Result: **Child → Left → Right → Base → object**.

No consistent order → `TypeError: Cannot create a consistent method resolution order`.

`super()` follows the MRO, not "the parent"

`super()` = "the next class after me **in the MRO of the instance's actual type**". In `Left.greet` on a `Child`, that's `Right` — a sibling. If every class calls `super()`, each implementation runs exactly once: **cooperative multiple inheritance**.

```python
class Base:
    def greet(self): return ["Base"]
class Left(Base):
    def greet(self): return ["Left"] + super().greet()
class Right(Base):
    def greet(self): return ["Right"] + super().greet()
class Child(Left, Right):
    def greet(self): return ["Child"] + super().greet()

class X: ...
class Y: ...
class A(X, Y): ...
class B(Y, X): ...
class C(A, B): ...        # A wants X before Y, B wants Y before X -> impossible
```

Output (`inheritance_mro.py`):

```
Child MRO: ['Child', 'Left', 'Right', 'Base', 'object']
Child().greet(): ['Child', 'Left', 'Right', 'Base']
C3 refuses: Cannot create a consistent method resolution order (MRO) for bases X, Y
```

Cooperative `__init__`: with differing arguments, take `**kwargs`, consume yours, pass the rest: `def __init__(self, *, color, **kw): super().__init__(**kw)`.

Trade-offs

Multiple inheritance	Pros	Cons
Mixins (small, stateless add-ons)	Reuse orthogonal (independent) behaviour cheaply	Name clashes, MRO surprises
Several "real" stateful bases	Rarely justified	Conflicting `__init__` signatures, fragile

Common mistakes

- Assuming `super()` means "the parent".
- Mixing `super()` with explicit `Parent.method(self)` → methods run twice or not at all.
- Listing a mixin *after* a base that already defines the method — the mixin is never reached.

Real-world examples

- Django class-based views: `class MyView(LoginRequiredMixin, ListView)` — mixin first so its `dispatch` runs before `ListView`'s.
- `socketserver.ThreadingMixIn` + `TCPServer` (TCP: the internet's reliable connection protocol — System Design Fundamentals) → `ThreadingTCPServer`.

In the interview

30-second answer: "The MRO is the linear order Python searches for attributes; it's computed by C3 linearization, which keeps children before parents, preserves the order of bases, and is consistent with every parent's MRO — so in a diamond the shared base appears once, last. `super()` delegates to the next class in the MRO of the instance's type, which enables cooperative multiple inheritance where each method runs once."

- *MRO of `D(B, C)` with `B, C` extending `A`?* — D, B, C, A, object.
- *When does class creation fail?* — Conflicting base orders.

TL;DR

MRO = C3: children first, bases in declared order, consistent with parents. `super()` = "next in the MRO", so cooperating classes in a diamond each run once.

10.6 Mixins

What it is

A **mixin** is a small class providing one capability (serialise — convert to storable text/bytes — to JSON, a nice `__repr__`, logging), meant to be *combined*, not used alone; usually no `__init__` or state.

```
class JsonMixin:
    def to_json(self) -> str:
        return json.dumps(self.__dict__, sort_keys=True)

class ReprMixin:
    def __repr__(self) -> str:
        fields = ", ".join(f"{k}={v!r}" for k, v in self.__dict__.items())
        return f"{type(self).__name__}({fields})"

class Product(JsonMixin, ReprMixin):
    def __init__(self, sku: str, price: float) -> None:
        self.sku, self.price = sku, price
```

Output:

```
mixins: Product(sku='A-1', price=9.5) {"price": 9.5, "sku": "A-1"}
Product MRO: ['Product', 'JsonMixin', 'ReprMixin', 'object']
```

Rules of thumb

1. Name them `…Mixin`. 2. Stateless (or cooperative with `**kwargs`). 3. List **before** the main base. 4. One capability each.

When not to use it

Lots of state/configuration → compose an object (§10.8). A plain function `to_json(obj)` would do → use it.

Real-world examples

Django `LoginRequiredMixin`, `PermissionRequiredMixin`; `socketserver.ForkingMixIn` / `ThreadingMixIn`; `collections.abc` classes supply concrete (implemented) methods like `Sequence.index`.

TL;DR

Small, stateless, single-purpose classes mixed in via multiple inheritance, left of the main base.

10.7 Abstract base classes, duck typing and Protocols

Three ways to say "this object must be able to do X".

Duck typing — what it is

"If it walks and quacks like a duck, it's a duck": Python calls the method and lets it fail if absent — any object with `.speak()` works in `make_it_speak`. It pairs with **EAFP** (try, then catch) over **LBYL** (check first) — §9.5.

Abstract base classes (ABCs) — what it is

An **ABC** (`abc` module) declares `@abstractmethod`s that subclasses **must** implement; instantiating a class with any left raises `TypeError` — at *creation*, not at the call. ABCs can also share concrete methods.

`collections.abc` has the standard ones: `Iterable`, `Iterator`, `Sized`, `Container`, `Sequence`, `Mapping`, `MutableMapping`, `Callable`, `Hashable` … Several (`Sized`, `Iterable`, `Hashable`, `Callable`, `Container`) implement `__subclasshook__` (lets a class decide what counts as its subclass), so `isinstance(x, Sized)` is

`True` for any class with `__len__`, no inheritance needed. `Shape.register(SomeClass)` declares a *virtual subclass*.

Protocols — what it is

`typing.Protocol` (PEP 544, 3.8) formalises duck typing for **static type checkers** (mypy, pyright): a class matches if it has the right methods/attributes — **structural typing**, no inheritance. `@runtime_checkable` enables `isinstance`, which only checks that the members *exist* (not signatures).

```
class Shape(ABC):
    @abstractmethod
    def area(self) -> float: ...
    def describe(self) -> str:                # concrete, shared
        return f"{type(self).__name__} with area {self.area():.2f}"

class Square(Shape):
    def __init__(self, side): self.side = side
    def area(self): return self.side ** 2

class Broken(Shape): pass                     # forgot area()

class Duck:
    def speak(self): return "Quack"
class Robot:
    def speak(self): return "Beep"

@runtime_checkable
class Speaker(Protocol):
    def speak(self) -> str: ...

def announce(s: Speaker) -> str:              # checked structurally by mypy/pyright
    return s.speak().upper()

class Deck:                                   # never inherits from Sized
    def __len__(self): return 52
```

Output (`abc_protocols.py`):

```
Square with area 9.00
TypeError: Can't instantiate abstract class Shape without an implementation for abstract method 'area'
TypeError: Can't instantiate abstract class Broken without an implementation for abstract method 'area'
['Quack', 'Beep']
BEEP | isinstance(Duck(), Speaker): True | isinstance(42, Speaker): False
Deck is Sized: True | Deck is Iterable: False
```

Protocols, generics and type checking in depth: Chapter 13 §13.8.

Comparison

	Duck typing	ABC	Protocol
Needs inheritance?	No	Yes (or `register`)	No
Checked when?	At call time (AttributeError)	At instantiation (TypeError)	By the static type checker; optionally `isinstance`
Shares code?	No	Yes, concrete methods	Not intended for sharing implementation
Best for	Small scripts, flexible APIs	Frameworks/plugins you own, enforced contracts	Library APIs, third-party types, typed codebases

When not to use them

No ABC for a single implementation "just in case" (YAGNI — "You Aren't Gonna Need It"). Don't rely on `@runtime_checkable` for correctness.

Common mistakes

- Not inheriting `ABC` (or `metaclass=ABCMeta`) — `@abstractmethod` has no effect.
- `type(x) is list` instead of `isinstance(x, collections.abc.Sequence)`.
- `isinstance(obj, SomeProtocol)` without `@runtime_checkable` → `TypeError`.

Real-world examples

`collections.abc.Mapping` for dict-like classes; `io.IOBase` ABC for files; `typing.SupportsInt`, `SupportsAbs`, `SupportsIndex` Protocols; the `numbers.Number` ABC hierarchy.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "Python is duck-typed: we care what an object can do, not its class. ABCs make that contract explicit and enforced — you can't instantiate a subclass until it implements every `@abstractmethod`. Protocols describe the same contract structurally, so a type checker accepts any class with matching methods, no inheritance needed. I use ABCs when I own the hierarchy and want shared code, Protocols for flexible, typed interfaces."

- *`isinstance(x, Sized)` checks?* — `__len__` on the type (via `__subclasshook__`), or registration/inheritance.

TL;DR

Duck typing = behaviour over type. ABC = nominal (declared inheritance), enforced at instantiation, shares code. Protocol = structural, for type checkers. `collections.abc` holds the standard interfaces.

10.8 Composition vs inheritance

What it is

Composition builds an object from parts it *has* (has-a: a `Car` *has an* `Engine`); **inheritance** says *is a*. Classic advice (Gang of Four, *Effective Python*): **"favour composition over inheritance"**.

Why it matters

Inheritance couples children to parent internals (the "fragile base class" problem: parent changes silently break children). Composition hides parts behind small interfaces, swappable at run time (a fake engine in tests, an electric motor in production).

```python
class Engine:
    def __init__(self, hp: int) -> None: self.hp = hp
    def start(self) -> str: return f"{self.hp}hp engine started"

class ElectricMotor:
    def start(self) -> str: return "silent motor started"

class Car:
    def __init__(self, engine) -> None:
        self.engine = engine                # injected part (dependency injection)
    def drive(self) -> str:
        return self.engine.start() + ", driving"
```

Output:

```
150hp engine started, driving
silent motor started, driving
```

Question	Inheritance	Composition
Relationship	is-a	has-a / uses-a
Coupling	Tight (sees parent internals)	Loose (only the part's interface)
Change at run time?	No	Yes (swap the part)
Code reuse	Automatic	Delegate explicitly (a few one-line methods)
Testing	Hard to replace parent behaviour	Inject a fake (passing parts in from outside = *dependency injection*)

When inheritance is right

Genuine is-a with substitutability (Liskov); framework extension points designed for subclassing (`unittest.TestCase`, `Exception` subclasses, Django `Model`, `nn.Module`); mixins.

Common mistakes

`class Stack(list)` — callers can `insert(0, x)` and break stack semantics; wrap a list. Inheriting just to reuse one helper.

In the interview

"I default to composition: it's looser coupling and easier to test and change at run time. I inherit when there's a real is-a relationship that satisfies Liskov, or when a framework is designed to be extended by subclassing."

TL;DR

Has-a → composition (default); is-a with substitutability → inheritance. Duck typing makes plugging in parts easy.

10.9 Encapsulation conventions: `_single` and `__double` underscores

What it is

No private keyword — encapsulation by convention ("we're all consenting adults"):

Name	Meaning	Enforced?
`name`	Public API	—
`_name`	Internal; may change. `from module import *` skips it	Convention (and linters)
`__name` (no trailing `__`)	**Name mangling**: inside class `Account`, `self.__secret` becomes `self._Account__secret` at compile time	Only prevents *accidental* subclass clashes; still reachable
`__name__`	Dunder: reserved for the language	Don't invent your own
`name_`	Avoids clashing with a keyword (`class_`, `type_`)	—

Why name mangling exists

To stop a subclass from accidentally overwriting a same-named parent attribute — **not** a security feature.

```python
class Account:
    def __init__(self) -> None:
        self._internal = "convention only"
        self.__secret = "mangled"            # stored as _Account__secret

class SubAccount(Account):
    def __init__(self) -> None:
        super().__init__()
        self.__secret = "child's own"         # stored as _SubAccount__secret
```

Output:

```
instance dict: {'_internal': 'convention only', '_Account__secret': 'mangled', '_SubAccount__secret': "child's
own"}
AttributeError: 'SubAccount' object has no attribute '__secret'
```

Common mistakes

`__x` everywhere to "make it private" — complicates debugging, pickling and subclass access. *Effective Python*: prefer `_protected`; reserve `__private` for clashes with subclasses you don't control.

TL;DR

`_x` = internal by convention (use this). `__x` = mangled to `_Class__x` against subclass clashes. Nothing is truly private; use properties to control access.

10.10 dataclasses

What it is

`@dataclass` (`dataclasses`, Python 3.7, PEP 557) reads **type-annotated** class attributes and generates `__init__`, `__repr__`, `__eq__`; flags add ordering, hashing, immutability and `__slots__`. Hand-written versions are repetitive and bug-prone (forget a field in `__eq__` and equality is silently wrong).

How it works

1. Each annotated class attribute becomes a **field**, in order. Un-annotated attributes (`x = 5`) and `ClassVar[...]` (true class-level variables) are ignored.
2. Defaults become `__init__` defaults; non-default fields can't follow default ones (unless `kw_only`).
3. `field(...)` customises: `default_factory=list` (fresh object per instance), `repr=False`, `compare=False` (excluded from `__eq__`/ordering), `init=False`, `kw_only=True`.
4. `__post_init__` runs after the generated `__init__` — validation, derived fields.

`@dataclass(...)` flag	Effect
`eq=True` (default)	`__eq__` comparing fields as a tuple — so the class is unhashable unless `frozen` / `unsafe_hash`
`order=True`	`<`, `<=`, `>`, `>=` comparing field tuples in declaration order
`frozen=True`	Field assignment raises `FrozenInstanceError`; with `eq=True` also generates `__hash__`
`slots=True` (3.10)	Generates `__slots__` → less memory, no new attributes
`kw_only=True` (3.10)	All fields keyword-only
`unsafe_hash=True`	Forces `__hash__` even when mutable — rarely right

Helpers: `asdict()`, `astuple()`, `replace(obj, **changes)` (copy with changes — how you "modify" a frozen instance), `fields()`.

```python
@dataclass
class Item:
    name: str
    price: float
    qty: int = 1
    tags: list[str] = field(default_factory=list)          # never `tags: list = []`
    _cache: dict = field(default_factory=dict, repr=False, compare=False)

    def __post_init__(self) -> None:
        if self.price < 0:
            raise ValueError("price must be >= 0")

    @property
    def total(self) -> float:
        return self.price * self.qty


@dataclass(frozen=True, order=True)
class Version:
    major: int
    minor: int
    patch: int = 0


@dataclass(slots=True, kw_only=True)
class Config:
    host: str
    port: int = 8080
```

Output (dataclass part of `dataclasses_enums_slots.py`):

```
Item(name='pen', price=1.5, qty=4, tags=['office']) | total: 6.0
eq ignores _cache: True
asdict: {'name': 'pen', 'price': 1.5, 'qty': 4, 'tags': ['office'], '_cache': {}}
post_init: price must be >= 0
mutable default: mutable default <class 'list'> for field tags is not allowed: use default_factory
order compares field-by-field: True | sorted: [Version(major=0, minor=9, patch=0), Version(major=1, minor=4,
patch=0), Version(major=1, minor=10, patch=0)]
frozen is hashable: stable
FrozenInstanceError: cannot assign to field 'major'
replace(): Version(major=1, minor=4, patch=7)
Config(host='localhost', port=8080) | has __dict__: False
```

`Version(1, 4) < Version(1, 10)` because tuples `(1, 4, 0) < (1, 10, 0)` compare numerically — unlike strings `"1.4" < "1.10"`.

Trade-offs — data-holder options

Option	Mutable	Validation	Speed/memory	Use when
`dict`	Yes	None	Fine	Truly dynamic keys, JSON
`typing.NamedTuple`	No	None	Tuple-light	Immutable records that should also unpack/index like tuples
`@dataclass`	Configurable	`__post_init__`	Good; `slots=True` for lean	Default for internal data
`attrs` (3rd party)	Configurable	Validators/converters	Good	More features; inspired dataclasses
Pydantic `BaseModel` (3rd party)	Configurable	Full parsing/validation of untrusted input	Heavier	API payloads, config files

Common mistakes

- `tags: list = []` → `ValueError`; use `field(default_factory=list)`.
- Missing annotation — `x = 5` is a class attribute, not a field.
- Expecting runtime type validation — annotations aren't enforced.
- `frozen=True` is shallow: a contained list can still mutate.
- Base field with default + subclass field without → `TypeError` (fix with `kw_only=True`).

Real-world examples

Configs, DTOs (data-transfer objects: plain records passed between system parts), events; Hugging Face `TrainingArguments` is a dataclass; FastAPI/Pydantic accept dataclasses.

In the interview

30-second answer: "`@dataclass` generates `__init__`, `__repr__` and `__eq__` from annotated fields. `order=True` adds comparisons by field tuple, `frozen=True` makes it immutable and hashable, `slots=True` saves memory. Use `field(default_factory=list)` for mutable defaults and `__post_init__` for validation. For untrusted input I'd use Pydantic instead because dataclasses don't validate types."

TL;DR

Dataclasses remove data-class boilerplate. Know `field(default_factory=…)`, `__post_init__`, `frozen`, `order`, `slots`, `kw_only`, `replace`, `asdict`.

10.11 Enums

What it is

An **enumeration** (`enum.Enum`) is a set of named, unique constant members (`Color.RED`) — singletons with `.name` and `.value`, iterable, compared by identity. They replace magic strings/ints (unexplained literals: `status == 3`, the `"acitve"` typo) with autocomplete, typo-proof names, a closed set of legal values and readable reprs.

Class	Behaves like	Use for
`Enum`	Its own type; `Color.RED == 1` is `False`	Default
`IntEnum`	Also an `int`	Interop with int-expecting code (`http.HTTPStatus`)
`StrEnum` (3.11)	Also a `str`; `auto()` gives the lower-case name	Values stored in JSON/DB as strings
`Flag` / `IntFlag`	Bit flags combinable with `|`, tested with `in`	Permissions, options (`re.RegexFlag`)

`auto()` assigns values (1, 2, 3 … for `Enum`); `@enum.unique` forbids aliases (two names, same value). Look up by value `Color(3)` or name `Color["GREEN"]`.

```
class Color(Enum):
    RED = auto(); GREEN = auto(); BLUE = auto()
class HttpStatus(IntEnum):
    OK = 200; NOT_FOUND = 404
class Env(StrEnum):
    DEV = auto(); PROD = auto()
class Perm(Flag):
    READ = auto(); WRITE = auto(); EXEC = auto()
```

Output:

```
Color.RED RED 1 Color.GREEN Color.BLUE
members: [<Color.RED: 1>, <Color.GREEN: 2>, <Color.BLUE: 3>] | identity compare: True
IntEnum == int: True | Enum == int: False
StrEnum: prod True
Flag: Perm.READ|WRITE | WRITE in rw: True | EXEC in rw: False
```

Common mistakes

- `member == "red"` with plain `Enum` → always `False`; compare to `Color.RED` or use `StrEnum`.
- `IntEnum` everywhere — unrelated int comparisons succeed silently.
- Modifying/adding members at run time — enums are fixed.

Real-world examples

`http.HTTPStatus`, `re.RegexFlag` (`re.IGNORECASE`), `signal.Signals`, Django `TextChoices`/`IntegerChoices`.

TL;DR

`Enum` for closed constant sets, `StrEnum`/`IntEnum` for str/int interop, `Flag` for combinable options; `auto()` for values.

10.12 `__slots__`

What it is

Instances normally keep attributes in a per-instance `__dict__` — flexible but memory-hungry. `__slots__ = ("x", "y")` reserves fixed storage for exactly those attributes and creates **no** `__dict__`. With millions of small objects (points, graph nodes, events) this cuts memory, speeds attribute access slightly, and stops typos from silently creating attributes.

```
class PointDict:
    def __init__(self, x, y): self.x, self.y = x, y

class PointSlots:
    __slots__ = ("x", "y")
    def __init__(self, x, y): self.x, self.y = x, y
```

Output (100 000 instances measured with `tracemalloc`, the stdlib allocation tracker, including the holding list):

```
100k objects: dict-based 12.8 MB vs slots 8.8 MB
slots block new attrs: 'PointSlots' object has no attribute 'z' and no __dict__ for setting new attributes
```

(Version-dependent — recent CPythons store instance dicts compactly, shrinking the saving.)

Caveats

- Only listed attributes; no `__dict__`, so no `vars(obj)`.
- No weak references (references that don't keep an object alive) unless `"__weakref__"` is listed.
- Every class in the hierarchy must declare `__slots__` (`()` if nothing new), or the subclass regains a `__dict__`.
- A slot can't have a same-named class-attribute default; `@dataclass(slots=True)` handles this.
- `functools.cached_property` needs `__dict__`, so it fails on slotted classes.

TL;DR

`__slots__` = fixed attribute set, no per-instance dict → less memory, no accidental attributes. Use for many small objects.

10.13 Pythonic design patterns (brief)

Full SOLID and all 23 GoF patterns are in the LLD Handbook: SOLID, creational incl. Singleton, structural incl. Decorator, behavioral incl. Strategy/Observer. First-class functions and modules shrink several of them:

Pattern	Classic (Java-style)	Pythonic
Strategy (swap algorithms)	Interface + one class per strategy	Pass a **function**
Singleton (exactly one instance)	Private constructor + `getInstance()`	A **module** (imported once, cached in `sys.modules`) or a `@functools.cache` factory
Command (action as an object)	Command class with `execute()`	A function, `functools.partial`, or a callable object (`__call__`)
Iterator	Class with `hasNext/next`	A generator function (Chapter 11)
Decorator (wrap to add behaviour)	Wrapper class implementing the same interface	`@decorator` functions (Chapter 12) — or a wrapper class for objects
Factory (creates other objects)	Factory class	`@classmethod` alternative constructor, or a dict mapping names to classes
Template method (base fixes steps, subclasses fill some)	Abstract base with hook methods	Same (ABC), or pass hook functions
Observer (notify subscribers)	Listener interface	A list of callbacks

```python
def no_discount(total): return total
def ten_percent(total): return total * 0.9
def bulk(total): return total - 20 if total > 200 else total

def checkout(total: float, strategy=no_discount) -> float:
    return round(strategy(total), 2)

@functools.cache
def get_settings() -> _Settings:        # lazily created, then always the same object
    return _Settings()
```

Output (`pythonic_patterns.py`):

```
no_discount  -> 250
ten_percent  -> 225.0
bulk         -> 230
<lambda>     -> 125.0
same object: True | debug: True
module cached once: True | in sys.modules: True
```

A Singleton is still global state and hurts testing — prefer passing dependencies; keep singletons for truly process-wide things (config, logging — `logging.getLogger(name)` returns the same logger per name).

In the interview

"In Python, a Strategy is usually just a function argument, like `sorted(key=...)`. A Singleton is usually a module-level object, because modules are imported once. I'd still use classes when the strategy needs its own state or several related methods."

TL;DR

Functions for Strategy/Command, modules for Singleton, generators for Iterator, `@decorators` for Decorator.

10.14 Chapter self-check

1. Two steps when calling `MyClass(...)`? → `__new__` creates, `__init__` initialises.
2. Why does `a.items.append(1)` affect `b` with class attribute `items = []`? → One shared list; mutation creates no instance attribute.
3. `class D(B, C)`, both subclass `A` — MRO? → D, B, C, A, object.
4. `__eq__` defined — instances in a set? → No, `__hash__` is `None`; hash the same immutable fields.
5. `v * 3` works, `3 * v` fails? → Implement `__rmul__`.
6. ABC vs Protocol? → Nominal, enforced at instantiation, shares code vs structural, checked by type checkers.
7. List default in a dataclass? → `field(default_factory=list)`.
8. `self.__token` inside class `Api`? → `self._Api__token`.
9. When do `__slots__` help? → Many small instances (no per-instance `__dict__`).
10. Pythonic Strategy? → Pass a function.

Chapter TL;DR

- **Classes** bundle state + behaviour; `__init__` initialises `self`. Instance attributes live in `obj.__dict__`; class attributes are shared (never a mutable one as per-instance state).
- **Methods:** instance (`self`), `@classmethod` (`cls`, alternative constructors), `@staticmethod` (neither). **Properties** add validation without changing the API.
- **Data model:** dunders connect your class to syntax and built-ins. Always `__repr__`; keep `__eq__`/`__hash__` consistent; return `NotImplemented`; `__r…__` for reflected operators; `total_ordering` for comparisons.
- **Inheritance:** `super()` = next in the **MRO** (C3: children first, bases in order, consistent). Cooperative `super()` makes diamonds safe. **Mixins** add small capabilities.
- **Contracts:** duck typing by default, **ABCs** to enforce, **Protocols** for structural static typing. **Prefer composition** unless it's a real is-a.
- **Toolbox:** `@dataclass` (`field`, `frozen`, `order`, `slots`, `kw_only`), `enum` (`Enum`, `IntEnum`, `StrEnum`, `Flag`, `auto`), `__slots__` for memory.
- **Encapsulation:** `_x` by convention; `__x` is name-mangled, not private.
- **Patterns:** functions for Strategy, modules for Singleton; details in the LLD Handbook.